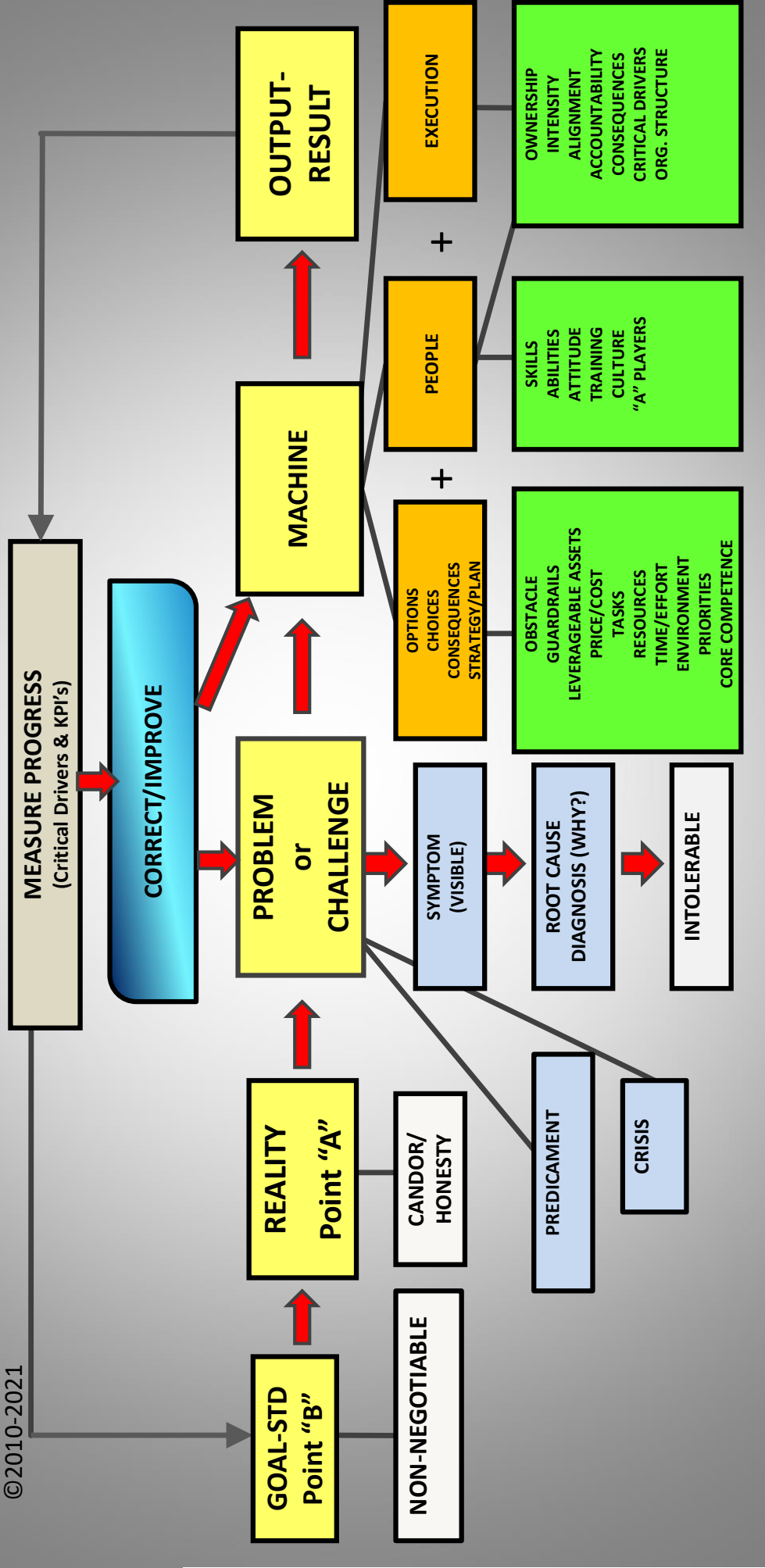


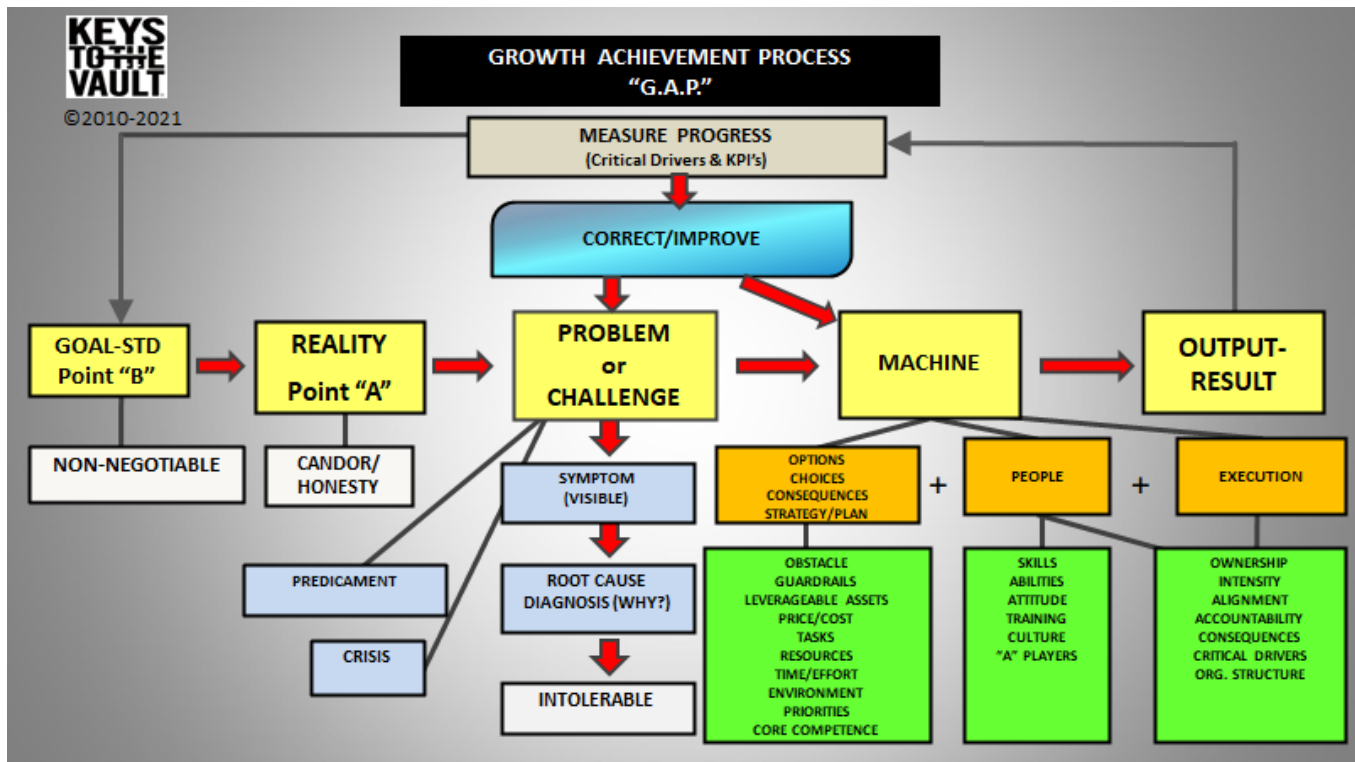
**GROWTH ACHIEVEMENT PROCESS
"G.A.P."**





GROWTH ACHIEVEMENT PROCESS

G.A.P. Analysis



The Growth Achievement Process ("GAP") is one of the most powerful tools in your arsenal because it forces you to get clarity on your Problem and then to design a Machine that will actually solve the Problem identified. The only thing standing between you and your Goal is an unresolved Problem.... Sadly, the unresolved Problem is also usually unidentified.

GOAL/OUTCOME

The G.A.P. starts with the intended Goal or Outcome. The key is to get clarity on the Outcome you want and then to make the achievement of this Outcome nonnegotiable. If the Goal is really a wish or a hope, find something else to work on.... Wishful thinking is daydreaming and is never a useful strategy for Goal achievement or success. The reality is this: We need fewer Goals and more Standards.... Raising your standard is a far superior strategy than setting new goals! Regardless of what we call it, clarity on the destination is critical.

REALITY

We tend to be experts at the Goal setting process... believing that if we just get clear on what we want we will somehow achieve (or “attract”) it. Certainly it is critical that we know what we want and where we are going with our business. The reality, however, is that it doesn’t do any good to know where you want to go if you don’t have a clue where you are and therefore don’t know what machine needs to be built to get you from where you are to where you want to be. This is the “Point A” Problem. Getting clarity on the Reality ‘That Is’ is the only way you stand a chance of solving the Problem ‘That Is’ and thereby making progress towards the desired Outcome.

Honesty and Candor are critical at this stage of the process... we typically need the support of a third party coach, advisor or friend to accurately assess our current status.

PROBLEM

The next step in the G.A.P. is to separate the Symptom from the underlying Problem. The Symptom is what is visible, but it is never the real Problem nor is it the Root Cause of the Problem. Sadly, we tend to gravitate towards fixing what is visible and therefore make no progress on our journey to accomplish the desired Outcome. Addressing the Symptom makes us feel better in the moment because we think: “At least I am doing something”. But confusing activity with productivity is a major saboteur of businesses and dreams. Being busy on the wrong thing is analogous to running the wrong direction enthusiastically and is a complete waste of time and effort. We want the sustainable forward progress (a.k.a. Kicking the Can”) that is only possible by identifying exactly where the can is that needs to be kicked.

In times of true crisis, however, the Symptom must be dealt with first.... Like when someone is admitted to the emergency room with an apparent heart attack. You can’t start a lecture about smoking and obesity at the point of admission. You must deal with stabilizing the patient and getting them off life support and out of crisis. In situations where the patient is not in a critical condition, then the best course of action is always to accurately identify the core Problem and diagnose the underlying Root Cause.

Too often, people get a headache (the Symptom) and repeatedly take an aspirin (until aspirin-taking becomes a habit) instead of figuring out the Root Cause of the headache and stopping the ‘hammer to the head’ activity (the Root Cause) which is causing the headache to begin with. This often requires peer input, brutal honesty and is frankly the most difficult part of the G.A.P. If you need to, you can take the time to try to figure out what is causing you to hit yourself in the head with a hammer. If this takes longer than about 15 minutes, you need to move on. At the end of the day, you will need to make a decision to stop the hammering regardless of why you are doing it. All the understanding in the world does not change the fact that if something needs to change, then the decision to change it is KEY to the change. (Click this link to “Just Stop It! <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ow0lr63y4Mw> to see a demonstration of what I just said.)

As we all know, a problem is simply an unanswered question. Getting to the Root Problem requires answering a simple question: Why? Why is this a Problem? How did this get to be a Problem to begin with? Why isn't this Problem already solved? Once you run out of answers to the "Why?" questions, you are probably getting close to the core Problem and the Root Cause.

One final point in the Problem Step of the G.A.P. Whatever you identify as the Problem must become Intolerable to you. Solving the Problem **MUST** become Nonnegotiable. A resistance to making the Problem Intolerable is simply a resistance to successfully solving the Problem. A resistance to making the Problem Intolerable is simply a way for us to stay in our comfort zone... and no one has ever been successful by embracing their comfort zone. Everything we want lies outside our comfort zone and everything we want demands a price.

Procrastination is the son of a lack of commitment to making the Problem Intolerable and without this level of commitment and decision making, you will ultimately fail. (Here is a hint: the things you have been procrastinating on doing are the things that are holding you back and retarding your progress.) Making the problem identified intolerable is simply another way of saying you are required to elevate your commitment from the "Best You Can" to **"Whatever It Takes."**

MACHINE

Based on the Problem identified, the question now is: What is the Machine (Solution) that must be built which will produce an Output which will move you towards the Desired Outcome? All Machines require:

1. A Plan or Strategy with well thought out possible Consequences in the event of success as well as failure. You must also take into consideration the Resources available to you, the Price or the Cost of this endeavor, the Environment you are operating in (a good idea yesterday might be a horrible idea today) and the Core Competence you have to actually pull this machine off.
2. People to design, build, run and monitor the Machine. People do not operate in a vacuum... they operate within a Culture. Give me a choice between great people in a lousy Culture and mediocre people in a great Culture and I will take the great Culture every time.
3. Consistent, Intense Execution with rewards for success and Consequences for failure.

OUTPUT-RESULTS-MEASUREMENT-CORRECTION

Your Machine (Solution) will produce certain Outputs or Results. The key is to Measure the Progress of the results being generated in comparison to the Goal/Outcome originally established. The question is whether or not the Machine is producing Results which are moving you closer to your Outcome. You are to use these Measurements to decide what Improvements

(or Corrections) need to be made to your Machine to enhance the Outputs and thereby accelerate the progress. The Machine can always be tweaked and refined, but these refinements are dictated by the Measurements. Measurement and Correction are THE keys to sustainability. The only constant in business is change. Ignoring change is a prescription for disaster. Change is not visible without measuring and comparing.